

Weekly Business Session: September 9, 2026

5:30 p.m. - Anne G. Basker Auditorium, 600 N.W. Sixth St, Grants Pass, Oregon

Present: Ron A. Smith, Chair; Colene M. Martin, Vice-Chair; Gary L. Richardson, Commissioner; and Nikole Guzman, Recorder

These are meeting minutes only. Only text enclosed in quotation marks reports a speaker's exact words.

Pursuant to notice through the media and in conformance with the Public Meeting Law, Ron Smith, Chair, called the meeting to order at 5:30 p.m. followed by the Pledge of Allegiance.

Items discussed were as follows:

1. DECLARE A POTENTIAL CONFLICT OF INTEREST

Commissioners Richardson, Martin, and Smith each declared no potential conflicts of interest.

2. REQUESTS/COMMENTS FROM CITIZENS

Ron Lamb, Josephine County, presented a proposed resolution declaring Josephine County a non-sanctuary jurisdiction. He referenced Douglas County's recent resolution and federal immigration priorities and asked the Board to formally express support for federal immigration enforcement to the extent permitted by law. Jack Dwyer, Selma, discussed his prior involvement with IVCaDo and concerns regarding water availability and the long-term economy and quality of life in the Illinois Valley. He described changes he has observed in Deer Creek and opposed activities he believes could further affect water quality or quantity, including strip and nickel mining. He expressed support for stronger protection of the Illinois River watershed.

Brent Wickes, Grants Pass, described difficulties accessing parking while using the YMCA and said a parking dispute with River Valley Church had limited his ability to shower while living in his vehicle. He stated that the lack of reliable access had affected his efforts to maintain employment and asked for clearer identification of parking available to YMCA users.

Kathleen Crone, Josephine County, spoke in support of Ron Lamb's proposed resolution. She expressed opposition to Oregon's sanctuary laws and supported greater local discretion and cooperation with federal immigration enforcement.

Brenda Sisson, Merlin/Grants Pass, supported a county policy statement similar to Douglas County's regarding sanctuary laws. She stated that she favors enforcement of federal immigration law and local law-enforcement cooperation with federal authorities where permitted.

Carol Valentine, Selma, opposed repeal of the federal Roadless Area Conservation Rule. She stated that roadless areas already allow certain activities under existing exceptions and emphasized the importance of protecting water quality, wildlife habitat, fisheries, recreation, and wildfire resilience.

Patty Pudesulege, Josephine County, supported efforts to oppose sanctuary status but asked the Board to explain what practical action the County could take given Oregon law. She encouraged a concrete strategy, including pursuing change at the state level if necessary, rather than relying only on a symbolic statement.

3. BOARD MAY REVIEW PUBLIC COMMENTS/QUESTIONS

Commissioner Richardson said a county resolution regarding sanctuary status would primarily be a statement of position and would not supersede state law. He said the County could advocate to the State for greater local control. He also discussed the proposed Outstanding Resource Water designation in the Illinois Valley, noting the County had requested a seat at the rulemaking table to address potential effects on Cave Junction, economic development, and future infrastructure. He advised Mr. Wickes that the Board Office had obtained information regarding YMCA parking and invited him to return to the office. Commissioner Richardson also discussed the pending federal Roadless Rule comment process and the County's interest in

participating in federal land-management decisions, wildfire-reduction projects, and possible forest-biomass economic development.

Commissioner Martin said she supports greater local control but emphasized that a county resolution would not change Oregon sanctuary law and could create unintended consequences if it jeopardized state funding relied upon by County programs. She encouraged those seeking a change in sanctuary policy to direct that effort to the State. She also acknowledged water-supply concerns in the Illinois Valley and said the County wants to participate early in state and federal discussions affecting local water and roadless areas.

Chair Smith said he obtained Douglas County's resolution shortly after it was adopted and provided it to the Josephine County Sheriff. He stated that the Sheriff viewed the resolution as largely symbolic because sheriffs and counties remain subject to Oregon law. Chair Smith said the Board could make a policy statement, but such a resolution would not change the County's legal obligations.

4. APPROVAL OF CONSENT CALENDAR

Minutes (draft minutes are available for viewing in the board's office):

Land Use Hearing Continued - August 31, 2026

Admin Workshop - September 1, 2026

Weekly Business Session - September 2, 2026

Legal Counsel Update - September 3, 2026

Executive Session - September 3, 2026

Commissioner Richardson moved to approve the Consent Calendar. Commissioner Smith seconded the motion. Upon roll call: Commissioner Richardson - Yes; Commissioner Martin - Yes; Commissioner Smith - Yes. Motion carried 3-0.

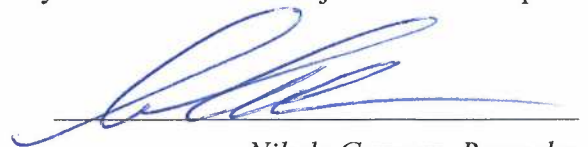
5. OTHER MATTERS: (ORS 192.640(1) ...Commissioners may introduce other matters for consideration by the entire board)

Commissioner Martin announced that Josephine County Economic Development Grant applications are open and available on the Finance Department section of the County website. She stated that approximately \$445,000 is available for projects supporting economic growth in Josephine County, that an advisory committee had been selected, and that the County intends to move toward a consistent annual grant cycle.

6. ANNOUNCEMENTS

Commissioners Richardson and Martin reported no additional announcements. Chair Smith wished his wife a happy 23rd wedding anniversary and thanked her for their years together.

Weekly Business Session adjourned at 6:06 p.m.



Nikole Guzman, Recorder

*Exhibit 1 – Ron Lamb Resolution
Exhibit 2– Jaya Feltzin Comment Letter*



**BEFORE THE BOARD OF COUNTY COMMISSIONERS FOR JOSEPHINE COUNTY
STATE OF OREGON**

In the Matter of)
EXPRESSING SUPPORT)
FOR THE PRINCIPLES)
AND POLICIES OF THE)
CURRENT, FEDERAL
ADMINISTRATION AND
DECLARING THE
COUNTY'S INTENTION
NOT TO BE A
SANCTUARY
JURISDICTION

Resolution No. 2026-00

WHEREAS, the Board of County Commissioners is charged with representing the interests of the citizens and ensuring the public health, safety, and welfare;

WHEREAS, the Board is committed to upholding the Constitution of the United States and the Constitution and laws of the State of Oregon, and to ensuring the safety, security, and well-being of all its residents;

WHEREAS, the Board recognizes the importance of clear policies regarding cooperation with all levels of government, including federal agencies, in the enforcement of laws duly enacted by federal and state legislative bodies;

WHEREAS, the current, federal administration has implemented various policies aimed at strengthening national security, promoting economic prosperity, enforcing immigration laws, and ensuring the rule of law;

WHEREAS, Josephine County wishes to affirm its support for principles and policies that uphold the rule of law, promote public safety, encourage economic stability, and ensure robust cooperation among local, state, and federal authorities;

WHEREAS, the term "sanctuary county" commonly refers to local governments that have adopted policies, ordinances, or resolutions that limit or discourage cooperation with federal immigration authorities in the enforcement of federal immigration laws;

WHEREAS, Josephine County opposes any Oregon State law that contradicts the current, federal administration and federal law;

WHEREAS, the Board of County Commissioners believes it is in the best interest of the citizens, and for the maintenance of public order, safety, and the equitable application of laws, that the County not operate as a sanctuary jurisdiction and instead fully cooperate with federal authorities to the extent required and permitted by law;

NOW, THEREFORE, IT IS HEREBY RESOLVED, as follows:

Section 1: Josephine County hereby expresses its appreciation and support for the efforts and policies of the current, federal administration that are directed towards enhancing national security, securing the nation's borders, supporting law enforcement, promoting economic growth, and upholding the consistent enforcement of federal laws.

Section 2: Josephine County, Oregon, hereby declares its intent not to be a "sanctuary county" and opposes the adoption of any state laws, policies, or ordinances, or resolutions that would cause it to be designated or operated as such.

Section 3: Josephine County will continue to support and cooperate with federal, state, and local law enforcement agencies in the lawful enforcement of all applicable laws, including federal immigration laws, to the extent permitted by the United States and Oregon State Constitutions.

Section 4: No county resources, funds, facilities, equipment, or personnel shall be intentionally used to obstruct or hinder the enforcement of federal immigration laws where such enforcement is being carried out in accordance with law. County officials and employees shall cooperate with federal immigration authorities in the discharge of their lawful duties, consistent with applicable legal requirements and limitations.

Section 5: This Resolution shall be effective immediately upon its adoption.

DONE and DATED this 9th day of September, 2026

**JOSEPHINE COUNTY
BOARD OF COMMISSIONERS**

Ron Smith, Chair

Coleen Martin, Vice Chair

Gary Richardson, Commissioner

My name is Joya Feltzin. I am a retired registered nurse, family nurse practitioner, and certified nurse midwife. I have lived here in the valley for 50 years and worked here in the health care field for most of them. I care about the health of our county's citizens, economy, and environment.

I am here to address three issues.

Homeland Nickel's and their associates' proposed nickel mines. Water is life. I believe that the proposed strip mining in and around our valley will tear up and poison our water and land. For example, take Woodcock Mountain. Many homes are upon and around that mountain. They get their water from the springs upon and the aquifer below the mountain top. The toxic runoff from the proposed strip mining there will poison their well water, their gardens, their livestock, their own bodies. This will be the case for every proposed industrial mine in and around our valley. Water flows downhill and streams flowing into the West Fork of the Illinois River, the Chetco River, the North Fork Smith River, Rough and Ready Creek, Josephine Creek, Deer Creek, Hunter Creek, and the Pistol River are all at risk of being poisoned by the toxic runoff from the proposed industrial mines.

The land that these proposed mines may operate upon is comprised of serpentine soil, a rare soil type found in few places on our planet. This soil is toxic to most common plants but specialized, unique rare wildflowers and other native plants have evolved to survive in the harsh soil. This botanically rich and unique area draws tourists and scientists from around the world. They come to marvel at and study our rare species and enjoy our beautiful forests and rivers. If we poison our water and land, we will destroy our growing tourism industry, our drinking water sources, our gardens and farmland. The mining operations will scarify hundreds, if not thousands of acres of land. The wildlife and endemic plants that live upon them will be killed. The ore trucks' traffic rumbling through our town and valley will pollute the air with dust and particulates and our soundscape with noise. This probable boom and bust enterprise will enrich few and ruin many of our valley's businesses.

There are better ways to meet our country's need for nickel. The US has been recycling stainless steel for its nickel content for years. There is no need to drill and strip mine our beautiful countryside for minerals.
Please say NO! to the nickel mines.

Second, I have heard that you are supporting the US Forest Service's plans to rescind the "Roadless Rule" which protects our wild lands from the negative impacts of roads. The Forest Service is unable to keep up with the maintenance of its current roads, yet wants to build more. These roads will increase fire danger to our communities by allowing more humans easier access to the interiors of our forests. I have read that humans cause more forest fires than lightening. Roads also allow the transport of pathogens into our forests. For instance, the soil borne pathogen *Phytophthora lateralis* that kills our Port Orford Cedar trees. It contaminates watersheds after being brought in on infected tires. Roads also increase erosion which causes more particulates to infiltrate our streams. This affects the clarity of our water and negatively affects our native fish.

Third, I would like you to support the proposed Outstanding Resource Water designation (ORW) for the Wild and Scenic Illinois River and Rough and Ready Creek. You must know that our region is renowned for its clear waters. Our amazing water quality is a gift to us and we should protect it. Water is life. Our watersheds are special for their fisheries, wildlife, diverse botany, and scenic qualities. Our waters are what draws thousands of tourists to our area to boat, fish, and swim.

Don't you want to help our county's economy improve? Not through a boom and bust industrial mining operation that will negatively affect our lives and tourist industry. Tourists bring their money to spend in our stores and purchase services with our river and fishing guides and outfitters. Destroying our wild, natural ecosystems will not further our economic growth. Industrial mining, increased road building in wild lands, and lack of protection of our precious waters are the wrong paths to take.

Please protect our beautiful home.

Thank you for your time,

Joya Feltzin